C2 Grammar

The subjunctive in formal English

Use the base-form subjunctive after verbs like insist and recommend, and were for unreal situations.

The subjunctive is rare in everyday English but common in formal writing, law, and set phrases. It is easy to recognise once you know the two main patterns.

Pattern	Form	Example
Mandative subjunctive	verb/adjective + *that* + subject + base form (no *-s*, no tense)	*The board insisted that he resign. It is essential that she be informed.*
Common trigger verbs	insist, recommend, suggest, demand, request, propose, require	*We recommend that the meeting be postponed.*
Common trigger adjectives	essential, vital, crucial, imperative, important	*It is vital that every student attend.*
Were subjunctive	*were* for all subjects in unreal situations	*If I were you, I'd accept. She acts as if she were the manager.*
Fixed expressions	formulaic phrases	*Long live the king. So be it. Be that as it may,...*

The negative has no *do*. Put *not* before the base form: *The doctor recommended that he not drive for a week.*

Common mistake. Adding *-s* or a past tense after the trigger: *They demanded that he pays* or *...that he paid*. In formal English say *that he pay*. British English also accepts *that he should pay*.

Practice

1. The committee recommended that the project ___ (delay).
2. It is essential that every employee ___ (complete) the training.
3. Correct the mistake: She insisted that he leaves immediately.
4. Make negative: The lawyer advised that the client ___ (sign) anything yet.
5. Complete with the subjunctive: If he ___ more careful, he wouldn't make these mistakes.
6. Rewrite with *should* (British style): We suggest that she apply early.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. be delayed
2. complete
3. She insisted that he leave immediately.
4. not sign
5. were
6. We suggest that she should apply early.